

Art of Prompting

In Questions Matter you learned what makes a question good, and that the skill is older than computers. When Socrates asked his famous questions, he aimed every one of them at a person.

A person meets your question halfway. Your teacher already knows what class you’re in. Your friend knows what happened last weekend. And when a person doesn’t understand you, they ask a follow-up before answering. AI does almost none of that. It starts from the words you typed, and instead of asking what you meant, it confidently answers whatever you gave it.

So asking AI good questions requires another skill: packaging it for something that isn’t a person. That’s prompting, and here’s why it pays off: **the quality of your prompt directly controls the quality of the response.**

START WITH A GOOD QUESTION

You learned the four qualities of a good question. Nothing about AI changes them. Every strong prompt starts life as a good question.

FROM QUESTIONS MATTER · THE QUESTION

1  **Open-Minded**

You haven’t picked the answer in advance.

2  **Specific**

It asks for exactly what you need.

3  **On Target**

It asks about the right thing.

4  **Open-Ended**

It leaves room for an answer you didn’t expect.

THEN ADD THREE MOVES

Packaging your question for AI comes down to three moves. There are entire classes on writing prompts, and here’s the secret: you don’t need one. You’re not training to be a prompt engineer. You’re learning to **Be Smarter Than the Tool.**

MOVE 1  **Share your situation**

A person already knows this. AI only has what you hand over.

- Who you are, and who the work is for
- What you’re working on and why
- The material itself: your draft, the assignment, the numbers

BAD

Is my intro good?

BETTER

I’m writing my Common App essay about how fixing cars with my dad taught me patience. Here’s my opening paragraph: [paragraph]. Does the hook grab attention?

MOVE 2  **Describe the answer you want**

The model fills in every blank you leave, so describe the target.

- The shape: a table, a list, steps
- The limits: length, what to skip, what not to sound like
- An example to match, if you have one
- Who AI should be: a tutor, a coach, an editor

BAD

Write a caption for our lacrosse championship photo.

BETTER

Write a caption for our team’s photo after the lacrosse state championship. One sentence. No hashtags, no emojis, nothing corporate. Sound like a senior wrote it, not the school account.

MOVE 3  **One job at a time**

Big work goes in steps. One prompt, one job, so each part lands and you can check it before you build on it.

BAD

Write me a 5–page paper on the Cold War with an outline, thesis, research, MLA citations, and a conclusion.

BETTER

Step 1: Help me shape a strong thesis for a 5–page paper on how the space race reflected Cold War tensions.

YOU DON'T NEED ALL OF THESE EVERY TIME

How much packaging does a prompt need? A quick factual question: none, just ask. Real work, like an essay or a project: share your situation and describe the answer you want. A big project: add steps. The more the result matters, the more you bring.

A prompt is a briefing, not magic words.

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